

UNTAMED ESCAPES AUSTRALIA HASA

Travel Radio Australia and we're at the World Travel Market in London and I've caught up with Craig Haslam from Untamed Escapes Australia. Craig, welcome to the program. G'day, please call me Hazy.

Everyone knows this is Hazy, so thank you for getting us to say hello. Now, Craig, where are you based in Australia, Hazy? Well, Hazy, where are you based in Australia? I live in Port Lincoln in South Australia, a lovely part of the world, but I do tours in South Australia, Northern Territory and Western Australia. I do budget tours, I do small group and I do private tours.

This is a fantastic service for people in Australia who want to see those regions who perhaps haven't been there. Let's start off with South Australia, which is your base. What can you do around there? So we do tours to Kangaroo Island, we do tours to the Flinders Ranges and we do different styles of tours.

We do shared tours, so people can jump on a seat on a bus or else we do private tours. And the private tours gives us the flexibility to be able to go over some beautiful sand dunes, to go to some lovely beaches, to include food and wines on that private package. So really it's about catering for the budget.

The budget one is a shared tour or a private one where you can really show the destination. Now, Hazy, there's been a number of films shot in South Australia in these regions that I remember from the 80s. I think Gallipoli was one of them and that's in your region and the vistas are absolutely magnificent.

Again, on those private tours, we can actually take them to those places. I think what I really enjoy about the private side of it is being able to meet the people, being nervous as a tour guide I am myself, but meeting the people and then doing something that they really want to do. Do they want to go to Gallipoli Beach? There's a new movie just out, Kangaroo Island Now, which I saw on the plane coming over.

Again, just showcasing the wildlife, the nature, the food and the wine. It's a fantastic region. Tell us about the other regions that you go to apart from that again.

Western Australia is a hidden gem as well. I've been lucky enough to travel all around Australia and do tours of most of Australia, but you can go to places like Cape Legrand in Esperance in Western Australia. The colours, the beach, the water, you give the opportunity for people to just sit down and enjoy it.

Sometimes from a touring perspective is that we try to do so much that we keep the people on the go. There's a place at Head of the Bite, which is my favourite place on the way to Western Australia, where on the right-hand side, we've got the Bunda Cliffs, which is 180 metres high by

200 kilometres. Spectacular.

On the left-hand side, the creamiest white sand dunes. Then during winter, you've got up to 120 southern right whales there. That is amazing.

Initially, when you take people there, the cameras go click, click, click, click, click, but then you take them back and just ask them to sit, take it all in, breathe deeper. It's an amazing special place in Australia. So if anyone is travelling through that region, whether it's on a tour or just on a self-drive, Head of the Bite, the Bunda Cliffs, it's amazing.

Yeah. I'm speaking with Craig Haslam from Untamed Escapes Australia. The funny thing is a lot of people go overseas, but they're very incredibly blown away by their own country and there's so much to see in Australia that is so undiscovered, isn't it? It is.

The other thing is, if you think in international perspective, they come to Australia for coastal, for outback, for wildlife, for food, for wine, for nature. We're a country that's got an abundance of that. And I'm very lucky as a tour operator, I get the opportunity to share that destination.

And you get quite humbled when you see the effect that it has on people. And then you know, it's a really special place. We're lucky to live where we are.

And those places, whether it's to Perth, up to Uluru, which we haven't even talked about yet, but the Flinders Range has just been made Lonely Planet's top 10. All of those places are spectacular. Speaking of Uluru, which was formerly known as Ayers Rock, it's a very, very special place for both tourists and locals.

Yeah. And I think what people don't probably appreciate is just how big it is. And you're only seeing a quarter of it.

The other three quarters under the ground. It is a special spot, a special spot to just take everything in and understand. And the Indigenous culture that you're able to share and give, you know, and give people Indigenous experience, blows people away.

All through Australia, we've got those Indigenous culture experiences. Western Australia is really, really special with it. But Uluru is, it takes your breath away every time you see it.

And what people don't realise, it is in the exact dead centre of Australia. Now, it just drives the mathematicians absolutely insane. Because if you put the points, it's like someone's placed it there with a slide rule, right? Is that a fact? It is.

It is. It's actually the dead centre from one degree. If it was off north, east, west or south by one degree, it will be off centre, which is really, really strange.

Like someone put it there like the pyramids or something. Well, I've been a tour operator for 20

years and I honestly didn't know that. It is true.

But, you know, most people in Australia also think when they go to Alice Springs, that Ayers Rock's just around the corner. I saw Uluru's just around the corner. So it's about actually changing that and actually changing the perception.

That's actually a journey going out there. Kata Tjuta, Kings Canyon, all beautiful places to go when you visit the centre of Australia. And, you know, I used to live on a farm in young New South Wales when I was 19.

And I actually went out with the Aboriginal trackers and spent a couple of days with them out there underneath that billion star sky. You can't really replicate that experience anywhere in the world. It's like being in a theme park or something.

And I'm sure you've seen that yourself being out there. The stars are amazing. And we take that for granted.

It's to be able to to be able to put a like a mat down and to be able to have everyone's heads together and to have a pointer and be able to identify the stars and to actually talk about like there's 88 constellations, 89 constellations in the sky, how they're made up, etc. And if you add the indigenous element to it as well, it's even better. So I feel it's a hidden gem for all of us.

And more and more people just got to get out of that city life and get out of those city lights and actually experience it. It is a fantastic experience if you ever get to do it. And and how can people find out more? Hazza, it's Craig Haslam, but everyone calls him Hazza from Untamed Escapes Australia.

How can people find out more about you and the company online? So our website is www.untamedescapes.com.au. The emails are there. We would just love to people to have a look at the different styles of tours. Do they want a budget? Do they want a small group? Would they like a charter? And then be able to say so that we can potentially tailor something for them.

The thing that what we need to do is we need to remember at the end of that journey that at the end of it, they say, well, that was something really special. So we start with that in mind, and then we build the package around that. So the end result, we want them to be blown away with some of the places that we're lucky enough to call home.

Hazza, you're an absolute legend. And I'm sure that all those people who've been out there with you will remember you for the rest of their lives and Untamed Escapes Australia. Thank you very much for being on Travel Radio Australia.

Thanks very much. I appreciate it. Cheers.